

BACKGROUND

Upon completing Army Nuclear Weapons Basic Maintenance Specialist Course at the Defense Atomic Support Agency at Sandia Base, Albuquerque, New Mexico on 4 June 1968, I received orders to report to the 525th Ordnance Company located south of Siegelbach, West Germany.

The Siegelbach depot was located about 40 kilometers south of Heidelberg and about thirty kilometers north of Heilbronn. Two companies, the 525th Ordnance Company and the 556th Military Police (M.P.) Company, manned the depot for the Advanced Weapons Support Command (AWSCOM) headquartered at Pirmasens, West Germany.

The 556th M.P. Company provided security for the base. The 525th Ordnance Company, especially the Assembly Platoon to which I was assigned, were charged with the depot critical mission of maintaining and servicing the special (tactical nuclear) weapons.

The weapons were stored in above ground bunkers in a restricted area (called the Exclusion Area or "The Hill"). That area was surrounded by two parallel double chain-link barbed wired fences supported by steel reinforced concrete support posts spaced every 10 or 15 feet. At night the Exclusion Area perimeter was completely illuminated by spot lights atop 20-30 poles with about a 40-foot interval between each pole completely surrounding the Exclusion Area outer perimeter. The lights illuminated the cleared 100-yard area from the outer barbed wire fence to the surrounding woods.

In between the barbed wire chain link fences were 40-foot tall dark forest green painted wooden guard towers spaced every 100 yards, or so, with a clear line of site between adjacent towers. Each tower had a catwalk around a windowed room at the top. The room was accessed by a single door and the cat walk was reached by several flights of wooden stairs. M.P.'s kept perimeter surveillance from atop the guard towers, and monitored everything below within the restricted area via jeep and ¾ ton truck two-man patrols. Each jeep had a mounted 50 caliber machine gun. All M.P.'s on duty in and around the exclusion area were heavily armed with ample supplies of ammunition upon their person and in each vehicle.

There was only one entrance-gate to the Exclusion Area located approximately in the middle of its western side. Adjacent to the gate and immediately south of the road that ran from the Hill to company barracks areas a quarter mile away was the M.P. guard building.

The Exclusion Area bunkers guarded by the M.P.s were above-ground Quonset hut-shaped reinforced concrete constructions with dirt heaped on top and on both sides. Each bunker had a large, heavy hinged steel blast door. To open the doors, it was necessary to first unlock the unique re-codable padlocks and then raise the doors with a pneumatic jack high enough so they could clear the steel track in which they rested. Only then could the heavy blast door be swung open.

The bunkers were in a configuration that lined the road that ran around the inside of the Exclusion Area perimeter on its north east and west sides. The road also ran along the west side, but no bunkers were on the west side of Exclusion Area save for the largest bunker in the northwest corner of the Exclusion Area.

The helipad was located on the west side of the Exclusion area mid-way between the interior perimeter road and another road east of the helipad connecting north and south sides of the perimeter. Bunkers lined that road on its eastern side. Exclusion Area bunkers were spaced 50 to 100 yards from one another and from the inside perimeter fence.

There was a concrete apron in front of each bunker used for loading and unloading that faced the access roads and which ran perpendicular to bunker entrances. The M.P.'s used the access roads to perform their constant vehicular surveillance. Electronic sensing devices were later installed and dog teams brought were later added to make the Exclusion Area even more secure. The M.P.'s were authorized to shoot to kill any unauthorized persons found between the two barbed wire fences marking the Exclusion Area Perimeter.

The total Exclusion Area was a huge trapezoidal space of many acres, the image of which was obscured in Google Earth satellite images for decades even after the depot was decommissioned. It is now a solar farm, and Google images show much of what is described above, sans the helipad, and the addition of a huge concrete tower on the west side outside the fence line. It appears as though many of the old wooden towers have been removed. The above-ground bunkers, however, are still plainly visible.

Despite their eternal vigilance, the M.P.'s who guarded the installation never knew what the Assembly Platoon did behind closed doors, nor did the M.P.s know what they were guarding. Such was the U.S. Army compartmentalization and access to classified information on a "need to basis" only.

Ironically, the old A.W.S.C.O.M. patch (pre-1970) showed a white nuclear mushroom cloud with a Hydrogen atom at its base which left little room for speculation. Eventually, A.W.S.C.O.M. received a new magenta and yellow patch with a box, key and a sun with rays at the top -- a rather ugly thing that was so cryptic that it no longer begged the question about whether or not there were nuclear weapons at Siegelbach.

The depot primarily stored and maintained Honest John¹, Nike Hercules², eight inch³ and 155 mm⁴ cannon round fission warheads. Pershing fusion warhead maintenance was added to the depot mission after 1969. Weapons testing and maintenance occurred in the largest bunker located in the

¹ The Honest John missile used a Mark 31 boosted Plutonium implosion sealed pit fission warhead with three yield variants of 2, 20, and 40 KT. It was the more sophisticated and accurate U.S. equivalent of a Soviet SCUD missile.

² The Nike Hercules used a Mark 31 20 KT boosted sealed-pit Plutonium implosion fission warhead. Designed primarily for surface to air defense, the Nike Hercules could also be used to attack ground (surface to surface) targets.

³ The eight inch round was a U-235 enriched Uranium (code named 'oralloy') gun assembly nuclear artillery warhead, fired from either an M110 howitzer or M115 howitzer. A total of 2,000 W33 projectiles were produced, the first being manufactured in 1957. Various versions of the eight inch warhead could produce yields from 5, 10 to 40 KT with the highest yield version being a boosted fission weapon. The W33 remained in service until 1992.

⁴ The 155mm (six inch) W48 artillery round was a Plutonium implosion sealed pit fission warhead with a yield of 0.072 KT. It weighed 120 pounds and could be fired from any U.S. 155mm howitzer.

northwest corner of the Exclusion Area. This bunker had blast doors located at both the east and west sides. The break area was located outside in to the south in two connected trailers. There, soldiers could smoke and have a heating element for their coffee machine without fear of an explosive honorable discharge from their U.S. Army enlistment.

THE INCIDENT

Late one evening in the early summer of 1970, I returned to the Siegelbach depot from a one or two-day pass.

While talking with someone in the Orderly Room, Perhaps Warrant Officer [REDACTED] who may have been Officer of the Day that night, M.P. Specialist 4th Class [REDACTED] ran into the building in a panic. He said an Unidentified Flying Object, or "U.F.O.," "buzzed" the Exclusion Area perimeter fence line and guard towers. He described how the object glowed a burnt-orange color when stationary. It was oval-shaped and about 30 or 40 feet in diameter. It hovered near the guard towers and above the double barbed wire fence line. When it moved from one location to another, it did so almost instantaneously, becoming a brilliant bright white, and then reappeared elsewhere, returning to a burnt-orange glow when becoming stationary again. Everyone on the "Hill", were spooked. It sounded as though some M.P.s felt so threatened that they left their guard tower posts. That's about all I could get out of [REDACTED].

[REDACTED] was literally bug-eyed when I talked with him. I had never seen anything quite like it before. It was obvious that what he described was a very real experience for him.

Another M.P. soon came into the Orderly Room with the same bugged-eyed panic. Apparently the two M.P.s in the jeep patrolling the interior of the Exclusion Area fled their post in panic, something tantamount to cowardice and desertion.

What I pieced together was that the U.F.O. entered the Exclusion Area and landed in the vicinity of the helipad near the west end entrance. There was one version where there were two objects, but I was unable to verify this or obtain any more information.

After [REDACTED] and other M.P. witnesses were interviewed by the Air Force and other officers who later came to the base, the witnesses were sworn to secrecy and told never to divulge anything about the incident to anyone. From then on, [REDACTED] and the other witnesses avoided saying anything about their experience. When I approached them and asked about it, they actually looked frightened and refused to share any details.

In a very strange development, [REDACTED] was assigned to the Assembly Platoon before being transferred to another unit. In all my experience working on special weapons for three years, that was the only time I ever saw anyone from another platoon or another company temporarily assigned to the Assembly Platoon.

Such a temporary assignment to the Assembly Platoon for someone who was not assigned to the Assembly Platoon was very unusual in that most Assembly Platoon soldiers had Top Secret Cryptographic security clearances. In comparison, the 556th M.P. Company soldiers, save their commanding officer, only had Confidential security clearances, which were two or three security

clearances lower than those held by Assembly Platoon soldiers who worked on special weapons.

██████ was removed from duty on the Hill and in the M.P. Company after the incident. He remained in the Assembly Platoon barracks a week or so before being reassigned to another place. We never knew where ██████ went, or what he did after he left Siegelsbach.

Other M.P. s who witnessed the U.F.O. or U.F. Os that night also were quickly transferred from Siegelsbach.

RETROSPECT

In follow-up to the incident, and perhaps unrelated thereto, around the same time Siegelsbach had a defective Mark 31 warhead from an Honest John weapon system.

In three years of servicing nuclear warheads at Siegelsbach, while on TDY on trips servicing Nike Hercules warheads at artillery units throughout southern Germany and while serving at the 510th Ordnance Company at the Massweiller Bunker, that was the only time I ever heard of a defective sealed pit Plutonium warhead. It was something that just never happened.

For weeks, the defective warhead sat along one of the walls in the main maintenance and testing bunker until it was shipped to the Pickitunny Arsenal in New Jersey. Upon testing at Pickitunny it was discovered that all of the warhead Fail Safe devices on that warhead save one had failed.

The Mark 31 warhead circuitry was tested using the T-283 Tester, a device that, but the twist of a knob at the bottom, generated a small electrical current that ran through the warhead circuitry. When the device was connected to the warhead and T-283 knob twisted, it gave a green light, or "Go" indication, or a red light, or a "No Go" indication. Had the knob been twisted hard enough, there could have been enough electrical current generated to set off a nuclear detonation. In the case of the Mark 31 warhead, the detonation would have ranged from 2 to 40 kilotons of explosive force. Hiroshima and Nagasaki were completely destroyed by detonations of 18 and 20 kilotons, respectively. A detonation in the 18-20 KT range would have completely destroyed the Siegelsbach depot and caused considerable destruction to the surrounding communities.

Whether or not the defective warhead could have been somehow related to the U.F.O. incident is something I had never considered until now.